

"People don't want to listen to an imitation. If they want to listen to my style, they will go and buy my records."

Begum Akhtar

Singer 1914-1974

QUEEN OF MELODY

She took classical music beyond the dry confines of orthodox purity, mixed it with the colourful shayari of poetic greats and presented it as a heady cocktail to delightful listeners

■ By Rita Ganguly

Music can be a powerful form of communication. And Begum Akhtar, in my opinion, was one of the first effective communicators. Sixty years ago, she realised the power of the medium and its ability to convey a message. Her notes carried a rare pathos which she zealously guarded as a stamp of her inimitable style and identity.

Today, at a time when classical music has fewer and fewer takers, Akhtar continues to be a rage. It has been 34 years since she passed away, but her recordings are still best-sellers. While poets recited *ghazals*, she brought them to the classical stage and made classical music accessible to the common man. She remains immortal for the sheer aestheticism of her vocal style.

The reason why Akhtar's music has endured is simple: she knew how to communicate with her audience. She was as careful in choosing the lyrics of her renderings as she was in delivering them in terms of diction and tonality. Having mastered the art of simplicity, she derived great satisfaction from the fact that her audiences expected nothing short of perfection from her. There was a personal rapport that Akhtar managed to achieve with each member of her au-

dience, almost as if she was singing exclusively for an individual listener. I once asked her how she looked so beautiful on the stage. She replied, "*Main unko dekhti hoon* (I see the Lord while singing)". That was the level of *bhakti* in her music—and life. She was a true Sufi.

Akhtar was born in 1914 in Faizabad of Uttar Pradesh. Her musical training began under Atta Ahmed Khan of Patiala. She not only learnt classical music but also the semi-classical forms like *ghazals*, *bhajans*, *thumris* and *dadras*. A broad-minded person who shunned the shackles of tradition, she believed in the empowerment of women. I happened to be taking lessons from the *thumri* queen, Sidheshwari Devi. But one day, Ammi (as I fondly addressed her) approached Devi and asked her if she could have me as her disciple. Once Devi agreed, she took me under her wings.

There and then, the *ganda bandh* (tying of the thread) ceremony was performed, with Devi making me wear her own Banaras silk sari for the ritual. The *ganda bandh* ceremony was the preserve of male students in those days, but that day, the tradition was broken. Akhtar was a reformer who was well ahead of her times. I remember the day when she took me to Cuttack to meet the

famous guru of Indore, Ustad Amir Khan, so that he could train me in voice culture. It is unthinkable today for a guru to think of all-round development of his or her students. She believed in promoting her *shishyas*.

I also remember how on a concert trip to Srinagar, she told me that I will be giving a solo performance on stage. I was stunned. She also told me not to sing from her repertory. I was speechless. All through the concert, she sat behind me. It was her unique way of promoting her students.

Akhtar was a secularist and a nationalist. After she received the Padma Shri, a few *maulvis* came to meet her. As she was a state awardee, the *maulvis* thought she was close to the government and could put in a word for their cause. They complained that their *masjid* at Barabanki had been taken over by Hindus, who were performing *puja* at the site. Ammi heard them out and asked to be excused. "After all, it is *ibadat* (prayers) that is being held there," she said. Even during the 1971, she would urge neighbours to switch off the lights at night. And when she heard the National Anthem on the radio, she would stand up. She was a true patriot.

The author, a renowned theatre artiste and singer, was a disciple of Begum Akhtar